

READING CHAIN

material and technique

- > posture / gesture
- > attribute / emblem
- > patron / inscription
- > site context
- > cross-site comparison
- > supported meaning
- > evidence limit

WHY IT MATTERS

The same motif changes meaning across chronology and setting.

Description must come before identification, and identification before inference.

The answer remains strong only if one explicit limit is stated.

HARAPPAN CORPUS

steatite -> so-called Pashupati seal / Bearded Priest

bronze -> Dancing Girl / Kalibangan bull

terracotta -> female figurines / models

CONTROL RULES

Undeciphered script blocks certainty about Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King.

Lost-wax technique is real continuity; fixed religious meaning is not.

Cow and lion are absent from the verified Harappan seal-and-terracotta trap bank.

Neolithic coarse ware

- > Chalcolithic painted wares (Ahar / Malwa / Jorwe)
- > Harappan red ware with black painting
- > Painted Grey Ware
- > Northern Black Polished Ware

RULE

Pottery is strongest for chronology, craft and material culture.

Pottery alone cannot prove theology, dynasty or language.

IMPERIAL LINE

pillars -> capitals -> polish -> state authority

POPULAR / RITUAL LINE

Yaksha / Yakshi -> fertility / nature cults -> absorption into major traditions

Shalabhanjika -> auspicious tree figure -> long survival

Narrative relief -> stupa railings and gateways -> symbolic Buddha presence

VERDICT

Court art and popular motifs coexist; one does not cancel the other.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: GANDHARA MATHURA AMARAVATI

School | Material clue | Scope | Safest significance

Gandhara | grey stone / stucco | mainly Buddhist | layered external visual idiom

Mathura | spotted red sandstone | Buddhist + Hindu + Jain | indigenous shared image grammar

Amaravati | Krishna-valley relief | mainly Buddhist | dynamic narrative storytelling

FINAL RULE

Compare on the same axis: material, patronage, visual logic and significance.

EARLY BUDDHIST SYMBOL SET

empty throne -> Great Renunciation

Bodhi tree / Vajrasana -> Enlightenment

wheel / lion / deer -> First Sermon

stupa -> Parinirvana

SHIFT RULE

Aniconism is symbolic presence, not absence.

Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerge in overlapping Gandhara and Mathura contexts.

SARNATH IDIOM

cream-coloured sandstone

thin drapery

subtle modelling

serene controlled face

CAUTION

Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer as late / post-Gupta.

Serenity alone is not enough; material and context must agree.

TEMPLE SURFACE AND RITUAL

Kirtimukha -> threshold / decorative force

Saptamatrikas -> grouped icon bank

musical pillars -> sculptural-performance link

Kalyanasundara -> marriage ritual rendered visually

bronze icons -> portable processional presence

RULE

Read motif, grouping and ritual use together.

Ravana Phadi, Aihole

- > earliest known example in this source bank
- > proves pre-Chola antecedent

Chola bronzes

- > lost-wax canonical portable form
- > temple procession and ritual visibility

RULE

Do not mistake the most famous form for the first form.

mudra -> what the hand says

attribute / avayudha -> who the figure is

vehicle / placement -> sectarian and spatial clue

attendant / grouping -> narrative or ritual context

posture -> action / mood / sacred mode

VERDICT

Identification and interpretation are linked, but only through context.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA

Harappan bull -> visible, meaning bounded

Mauryan capitals -> imperial and sacred coding

Sarnath abacus -> lion and bull in one Buddhist programme

Nandi mandapa -> Shaiva bull with architectural place

Yali / Vyala -> leonine-hybrid guardians in later temple surface

RULE

Motif continuity survives; exact meaning changes.

SOCIAL EVIDENCE

sculpture shows patron-selected visibility,
ritual, dress, gesture, performance and craft.

It does not give a full photographic census of society.

TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY

Harappan figurines / models

- > Chandraketugarh craftsmanship
- > Gupta plaques
- > Bengal terracotta-brick facades

FINAL RULE

Every answer should end with one honest evidentiary limit.